

# There Must Be Some Kind of Mistake: Distinguishing Errors from Uncertainty in Type Checking

A recent paper by Garby, Bahr, and Hutton proposes a relational specification for type checkers, where types computed statically are related to the types of computational results. The relation in question makes type errors smaller than non-error types. This paper refines this relation by introducing explicit types for terms which are guaranteed to exhibit runtime errors of various kinds. These error types are distinct from a type representing uncertainty about the term's runtime behavior. The two kinds of errors considered are finite failure and divergence. To manage the complexity induced by the richer partial order on types, the paper uses a monadic type checker, which is then related to a fuel-bounded monadic interpreter. Proof complexity is also managed monadically, using a binary indexed monad to relate typing and evaluation. The verification is carried out in Agda.

CCS Concepts: • **Software and its engineering** → **Formal software verification**; • **Theory of computation** → **Program verification**; **Type theory**.

Additional Key Words and Phrases: type checking, nontermination, type errors, monads

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## 1 INTRODUCTION

Garby et al. [3] present the derivation of a type checker for a simple expression language, in the style of program calculation. With this approach, one tries to prove a specification about code that has yet to be determined, and discovers the definitions (or constraints on them) necessary in the course of attempting to complete the proof. Their specification states that the type computed by the type checker  $\text{texp}$  for an *Expr*  $e$  is an approximation to the true type of  $e$ . The true type is the type computed (by a function  $\text{tval}$ ) for the value of  $e$ , as produced by an evaluator  $\text{eval}$ . The approximation ( $\leq$ ) states that the *ERROR* type returned by the type checker to signal a type error approximates any of the types for values. With the types shown in Figure 1 (following the authors in writing Haskell with unicode), their specification is

$$\text{texp } e \leq \text{tval } (\text{eval } e)$$

While acknowledging that usually one would implement the evaluator monadically to handle runtime errors, they opt to use simpler typing, and include *Error* as a *Value*.

In this paper, we build on the prior work of Garby et al. in the following ways:

- (1) We extend the ordering on types to distinguish known errors from uncertainty. So we now have types *UNKNOWN* and *FAIL*. If an expression is of type *FAIL*, that means that it is guaranteed to produce a runtime error. *UNKNOWN* represents a term whose runtime behavior cannot be assessed by the type checker.

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```

50 data Value = I Int | B Bool | Error
51 data Expr = Val Value | Add Expr Expr | If Expr Expr Expr
52 data Type = INT | BOOL | ERROR
53
54 tval :: Value -> Type
55 texp :: Expr -> Type
56 eval :: Expr -> Value
57
58 instance Ord Type where
59   t ≤ t' = t == ERROR || t == t'
60

```

Fig. 1. Definitions from Garby et al. [3]

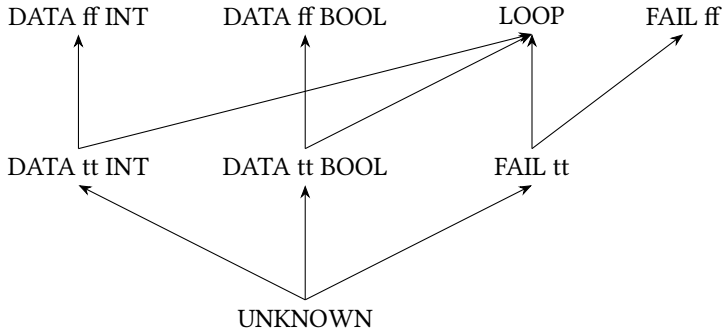


Fig. 2. The partial order on types in this paper

- (2) We add possibly diverging computation to the simple expression language, via a form of unbounded search. This leads to richer typing: instead of just `BOOL` and `INT` for terms producing values of those types, we now distinguish between terms which are known to terminate or ones which might diverge. So we have types `BOOL b` and `INT b`, where boolean `b` indicates either possible divergence (`True`) or guaranteed termination (`False`). The `FAIL` type is updated similarly, to distinguish terms that are guaranteed to fail at runtime, from those that fail or else diverge. For computations that are *guaranteed* to diverge, we add a type `LOOP`. The partial order on these types is depicted in Figure 2. More approximate types are lower in the order, which is discussed further in Section 5.1.
- (3) To manage programming with this more complex ordering on types, we adopt monadic definitions of the type checker and the evaluator.
- (4) We then prove the specification proposed by Garby et al. [3], in Agda. Here, we must relate the two monadic computations of typing and evaluation. To do this concisely, our proof uses a binary indexed monad, to factor out the reasoning associated with the cases that the typing and evaluation monads abstract.

The motivation for this development is to enrich the kind of information the type checker can provide. Usually (and in Garby et al. [3]), type checkers do not distinguish between situations that might lead to runtime errors, and those which must. Such a distinction would pave the way for providing new error information to programmers, when their programs do not pass the type checker. One might wish, for example, to report example inputs to a function which are guaranteed to lead to a runtime error. It is common practice to provide such information in the world of model

```

99  data Val : Set where
100    I :  $\mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \text{Val}$ 
101    B :  $\mathbb{B} \rightarrow \text{Val}$ 
102
103  data Expr : Set where
104    Var : Expr
105    Value : Val  $\rightarrow$  Expr
106    Add : Expr  $\rightarrow$  Expr  $\rightarrow$  Expr
107    IsZero : Expr  $\rightarrow$  Expr
108    Cond : Expr  $\rightarrow$  Expr  $\rightarrow$  Expr  $\rightarrow$  Expr
109    Search : Expr  $\rightarrow$  Expr

```

Fig. 3. Values and expressions

checking, in the form of error traces [4]. Formalizing such error reporting remains, however, for future work. We here just address the issue of relating typing and evaluation with a more refined notion of untypability.

All code following is written in Agda (checked with version 2.7.0.1), making modest use of an [alternative standard library](#) for basic data structures. Readers unfamiliar with Agda will find that our code looks very similar to Haskell, except for the use of unicode and user-defined infix syntax, where underscores in the names of functions indicate argument positions. Here is a brief summary of other Agda features we use. Pattern-matching equations can be extended to match on an additional expression using `with`. The additional argument is listed following a `|` in subsequent equations. The library provides types  $\mathbb{Z}$  of integers,  $\mathbb{N}$  of unary natural numbers, and  $\mathbb{B}$  of booleans, with values `tt` and `ff`. Unlike Haskell, Agda allows the same name to be used for a constructor of two different types, but the same name may not be used at both the term and type levels (because the notion of level is more complex in Agda). Finally, inputs to functions can be designated implicit using curly braces. Agda tries to infer values for those at call sites. Occasionally this fails, and then the programmer may resort to writing those arguments explicitly, in curly braces.

## 2 THE EXPRESSION LANGUAGE

The syntax for values and expressions is in Figure 3. Similarly to Garby et al., we work with a first-order language with integer and boolean values. Our expression syntax includes values (`Value`), additions (`Add`), and conditionals (`Cond`), just like Garby et al. We add a test for zero (`IsZero`), to have a way to compute a boolean. Most notably, we add a construct (`Search`) that searches for a natural-number value that makes an expression evaluate to zero. The value is substituted for a sole variable (`Var`) allowed by the language.

## 3 THE EVALUATOR

The evaluator produces one of three possible results, as shown in Figure 4. It could produce a value (`Value`), failure (`Fail`), or report that it ran out of fuel (`Unfinished`). We are using a standard simple technique for incorporating possibly diverging functions into a total programming language (here, Agda), where the function takes in an extra natural-number input, bounding the number of steps of computation. If this fuel parameter reaches zero and the computation is not complete, then our evaluator will return `Unfinished`.

```

148 data Result (V : Set) : Set where
149   Value : V → Result V
150   Fail : Result V
151   Unfinished : Result V

```

Fig. 4. Results produced by the evaluator

```

154
155 infixr 8 _>>=r_
156
157 _>>=r_ : ∀{A B : Set} → Result A → (A → Result B) → Result B
158 Value x >>=r r = r x
159 Fail >>=r r' = Fail
160 Unfinished >>=r r' = Unfinished
161
162 returnr : ∀{A : Set} → A → Result A
163 returnr = Value
164
165 instance
166   ResultMonad : Monad Result
167   ResultMonad = record { return = returnr ; _>>=_ = _>>=r_ }

```

Fig. 5. Monadic combinators for Result

To reduce boilerplate in the evaluator, we define `Result` as a monad, with the code in Figure 5. Values are propagated by `>>=`, but `Fail` and `Unfinished` terminate computation. We make use of Agda's approach to type classes using an instance block, to declare that `Result` is a monad.

Finally, we define the evaluator with typing

```

175 eval : ℕ → Expr → ℕ → Result Val

```

In call `eval g e v`, the natural `g` is the fuel, and `v` is the value for the sole variable. We follow the proposed structure of Garby et al., by having a helper function for each case of evaluation. So for evaluating an `Add` expression, we have a helper function `add`. Garby et al. give this helper the type `Value → Value → Value`. This simple type hides some complexity, because `Error` is included in their type for values. Here, using the monadic structure of `Result` we write:

```

182 add : Val → Val → Result Val
183 add (I x) (I y) = return (I (x +ℤ y))
184 add _ _ = Fail

```

Our type `Val` of values does not include errors (see Figure 3), so to return `Fail`, the return type of `add` must use `Result`. The test for zero has just as simple a helper function:

```

187 isZero : Val → Result Val
188 isZero (I x) = return (B (x =ℤ 0ℤ))
189 isZero _ = Fail

```

It returns a boolean value if given an integer, and otherwise fails.

Because conditional is lazy in its then- and else-parts, we write the following helper for `Cond`:

```

193 cond : Val → Result Val → Result Val → Result Val
194 cond (B x) y z = if x then y else z
195 cond _ _ _ = Fail

```

```

197 eval : ℕ → Expr → ℕ → Result Val
198 eval g Var v = return (I (toℤ v))
199 eval g (Value x) v = return x
200 eval g (Add e1 e2) v =
201   do
202     r1 ← eval g e1 v
203     r2 ← eval g e2 v
204     add r1 r2
205 eval g (IsZero e) v =
206   do
207     r ← eval g e v
208     isZero r
209 eval g (Cond e1 e2 e3) v =
210   do
211     b ← eval g e1 v
212     cond b (eval g e2 v) (eval g e3 v)
213 eval g (Search e) _ = search g (eval g e)

```

Fig. 6. The evaluator

This takes in terms of type `Result Val` for then- and else-parts, representing that computation is not strict in those.

Deferring the code for search for a moment, this brings us to the definition of `eval` in Figure 6. We use `do`-notation (supported by Agda) to use the monadic combinators for `Result`. In the case for `IsZero`, for example, we bind the result of the recursive call `eval g e v` to `r`, which then has type `Val`. This value is given to the helper function `isZero`, which returns a value of type `Result Val`, as required by the return type of `eval`.

### 3.1 Implementing Search

The missing piece of the evaluator is the code to process `Search` expressions. This is given by helper function `search` in Figure 7. Some extension of Garby et al. [3] is required at this point, because on their methodology, the helper functions in the various cases of `eval` should be presented with values (`Val`), or perhaps results of computation (`Result Val`). But for `Search e`, we need to try evaluating `e` repeatedly with different values for the variable. So it seems that the helper function `search` might need to deviate from the approach in Garby et al. [3], since it cannot take just a single value or result.

We solve this problem by calling `search` with the partial application `eval g e`, which is missing the argument for the value of the sole variable of `e`. The type of this partial application is  $\mathbb{N} \rightarrow \text{Result Val}$ , which is what the code for `search` in Figure 7 expects for its second argument `vv`. The code for `search` binds the value of `vv` on the current fuel `g`, and then calls the mutually recursive helper `searchh`. That function checks to see if the value is integer zero. If so, it returns `g` (in the `Result` monad). Otherwise, it either reports `Unfinished` if the fuel has been exhausted, or else recursively continues the searches for a zero, decrementing the fuel from `suc g` to `g` (in the last equation of Figure 7).

```

246 mutual
247   search :  $\mathbb{N} \rightarrow (\mathbb{N} \rightarrow \text{Result Val}) \rightarrow \text{Result Val}$ 
248   search g vv =
249     do
250       d  $\leftarrow$  vv g
251       searchhh g vv d
252   searchhh :  $\mathbb{N} \rightarrow (\mathbb{N} \rightarrow \text{Result Val}) \rightarrow \text{Val} \rightarrow \text{Result Val}$ 
253   searchhh g vv (B x) = Fail
254   searchhh g vv (I x) with x =  $\mathbb{Z} \ 0\mathbb{Z}$ 
255   searchhh g vv (I x) | tt = return (I (to $\mathbb{Z}$  g))
256   searchhh zero vv (I x) | ff = Unfinished
257   searchhh (suc g) vv (I x) | ff = search g vv

```

Fig. 7. The helper function for searching for a zero

```

260
261 data Data : Set where
262   INT : Data
263   BOOL : Data
264
265 data RType : Set where
266   DATA : (c : Data)  $\rightarrow$  RType
267   UNFINISHED : RType
268   FAIL : RType
269
270 data EType (X : Set) : Set where
271   DATA : (b :  $\mathbb{B}$ )(c : X)  $\rightarrow$  EType X
272   FAIL :  $\mathbb{B} \rightarrow$  EType X
273   UNKNOWN : EType X
274   LOOP : EType X

```

Fig. 8. The syntax of runtime types (RType) and static types (EType)

#### 4 THE SYNTAX OF TYPES

Our aim is to define a type checker `texp` satisfying the following version of the specification of Garby et al. [3]:

```
texp e  $\ll$  tresult (eval g e v)
```

We will need a function `tresult` to compute a type for a value of type `Result Val`, produced by `eval`. Differently from Garby et al., the relation  $\ll$  that we use relates two different kinds of types. The type produced by `texp` has Agda type `EType Data`, representing static types. The type produced by `tresult` has Agda type `RType`, for runtime types. The definitions are in Figure 8. There is an Agda type `Data` for types common to both runtime and static. Constructors `DATA` (taking an argument of type `Data`) and `FAIL` are common to both datatypes. In the static case (`EType`), these constructors take a boolean argument indicating whether the terms might diverge (`tt`) or certainly terminate (`ff`). For the situation where the evaluator runs out of fuel and returns `Unfinished`, we have runtime type `UNFINISHED`. Statically, we will use a simple positivity analysis to detect if the search for a zero cannot possibly succeed (presented in Section 5.2). In that case, the static type is `LOOP`. Finally, static type `UNKNOWN` represents uncertainty, as generally inherent to type checking.

```

295 _>=>e_ : ∀{A B : Set} → EType A → (A → EType B) → EType B
296 DATA b t >=>e f = b ↓ f t
297 FAIL b >=>e f = FAIL b
298 UNKNOWN >=>e f = UNKNOWN
299 LOOP >=>e f = LOOP
300
301 returne : ∀{A : Set} → A → EType A
302 returne x = DATA ff x
303
304 instance
305   ETypeMonad : Monad EType
306   ETypeMonad = record { return = returne ; _>=>_ = _>=>e_ }
307

```

Fig. 9. Monadic combinators for EType

```

310 _↓_ : ∀{A : Set} → ℬ → EType A → EType A
311 b ↓ DATA b' t = DATA (b || b') t
312 b ↓ FAIL b' = FAIL (b || b')
313 b ↓ t = t
314

```

Fig. 10. Relaxing the possibility of divergence in a type

The type constructor EType is a monad, as shown by the code in Figure 9. The definition of bind (>=>e) for EType expresses that known failure (FAIL), uncertainty (UNKNOWN), and known divergence (LOOP) cut off type checking. This leaves the case where we are binding an EType A of the form DATA b t. This is when type checking has determined that a term has Data type t, with boolean b indicating possibility of divergence. In this case, we send t to the functional argument of bind. But we use b to relax the EType returned by f t. For if b indicates possible divergence, that possibility should be retained. This is implemented by the call b ↓ f t, using the function ↓ defined in Figure 10. If the type to be relaxed is of the form DATA b' t or FAIL b', then the relaxation uses b || b' for the possibility of divergence. This means that if either the current type or the input b indicate that divergence is possible, then so does the resulting type. Otherwise, relaxation does not affect the type.

## 5 THE TYPE CHECKER

Typing of values and results is shown in Figure 11. Integer values (I) have type INT, and boolean values (B) BOOL. This is computed by tval. RTypes are computed for Result Vals by tresult, in the obvious way: Fail has type FAIL, and Unfinished UNFINISHED. Value results are mapped to Data types.

The type checker texp for expressions follows the structure proposed by Garby et al.: there is a helper function for each form of expression. Here, since our type checker is monadic, the helper functions are called with Data types (i.e., values of type Data, from Figure 8), and produce Data types in the EType monad. For Add and IsZero expressions, the helper functions are straightforward:

```

339 add' : Data → Data → EType Data
340 add' INT INT = return INT
341 add' _ _ = FAIL ff
342
343

```

```

344 tval : Val → Data
345 tval (I _) = INT
346 tval (B _) = BOOL
347
348 tresult : Result Val → RType
349 tresult (Value v) = DATA (tval v)
350 tresult Fail = FAIL
351 tresult Unfinished = UNFINISHED

```

Fig. 11. Typing of results and values

```

355 isZero' : Data → EType Data
356 isZero' INT = return BOOL
357 isZero' _ = FAIL ff

```

For conditionals (Cond), the helper function needs to combine the ETypes obtained for the then- and else-parts. We follow Garby et al. in using the order-theoretic perspective, and defining

```

360 cond' : Data → EType Data → EType Data → EType Data
361 cond' BOOL t1 t2 = t1  $\sqcap$  t2
362 cond' _ _ _ = FAIL ff

```

Here,  $t1 \sqcap t2$  is the greatest lower bound of the ETypes  $t1$  and  $t2$ , in the ordering on static types, discussed next.

## 5.1 More on the Partial Order for Static Types

Consider in more detail Figure 2 from the introduction. This shows the partial order on ETypes, from which  $\sqcap$  is derived. At the bottom of the order we have UNKNOWN, and as we proceed upwards, we gain certainty. The types DATA  $tt$  INT, DATA  $tt$  BOOL, and FAIL  $tt$  are one level above UNKNOWN. The boolean  $tt$  represents the possibility of divergence. So the type DATA  $tt$  INT is for terms which either diverge or else produce an integer value. And the type FAIL  $tt$  is for terms which either diverge or exhibit a runtime error, like trying to add an integer to a boolean. These types express less certainty than the similar types one level higher with boolean  $ff$ . For example, DATA  $ff$  INT is for terms which are guaranteed to terminate with an integer value. There is no uncertainty about termination. Finally, the type LOOP is for terms guaranteed to diverge. This again reflects greater certitude than the types like DATA  $tt$  INT.

This ordering is implemented in the code for  $\sqcap$ , shown in Figure 12. The last two equations use the  $\Downarrow$  function of Figure 10 to relax the possibility of divergence in a type. For example, suppose we are combining LOOP with, say, FAIL  $ff$ . For conditionals, this could represent having a then-part that is known to diverge, and an else-part that is known to fail. Since we do not know statically which branch will be taken, the best we can do for the type of the whole conditional is FAIL  $tt$ , representing the fact that the term either diverges or else exhibits a runtime error. This is what will be produced by the call  $tt \Downarrow (FAIL\ ff)$ , and is indeed the greatest lower bound of those types, in the ordering of Figure 2.

## 5.2 Positivity analysis

The final helper function needed for the type checker `texp` is for Search expressions. We use this as an opportunity to consider static detection of divergence, where the type checker returns type LOOP. This is done here with a simple positivity analysis for expressions (much like one that forms an initial example in Garby et al. [3]). This analysis will be sound but on purpose, not complete



```

393  $\sqcap\_ : \text{EType Data} \rightarrow \text{EType Data} \rightarrow \text{EType Data}$ 
394  $t \sqcap \text{UNKNOWN} = \text{UNKNOWN}$ 
395  $\text{UNKNOWN} \sqcap t = \text{UNKNOWN}$ 
396  $\text{DATA } b \ c \sqcap \text{DATA } b' \ c' = \text{if } c = c' \text{ then DATA } (b \ || \ b') \ c \text{ else UNKNOWN}$ 
397  $\text{DATA } \_ \_ \sqcap \text{FAIL } \_ = \text{UNKNOWN}$ 
398  $\text{FAIL } \_ \sqcap \text{DATA } \_ \_ = \text{UNKNOWN}$ 
399  $\text{FAIL } b \sqcap \text{FAIL } b' = \text{FAIL } (b \ || \ b')$ 
400  $t \sqcap \text{LOOP} = tt \Downarrow t$ 
401  $\text{LOOP} \sqcap t = tt \Downarrow t$ 

```

Fig. 12. The greatest lower bound of ETypes, with respect to the ordering depicted in Figure 2

for solvability of integer expressions. Small extensions of the language (for example, including multiplication and multiple variables) would make that problem undecidable, so it is in fact more illustrative of the general situation to adopt a sound but incomplete analysis. If the linear integer polynomial is strictly positive, then it has no solution. So we test for this property.

We follow the pattern established already above. We take a monadic definition for `Sign`, to account for the approximate nature of the analysis. This is shown in Figure 13. Signs are either `Known`, containing a boolean indicating either strictly positive (`tt`) or nonnegative (`ff`), or else `Unknown`. We make `Sign` a monad by having `Unknown` cut off the computation. Figure 14 then gives the code for computing signs for values, results, and expressions. The code for `sval` matches on the form of integers in the library we are using. They are either `mkZ zero triv` for zero, `mkZ (suc n) tt` for a strictly positive number, or `mkZ (suc n) ff` for a strictly negative one. We label the latter as `Unknown`, because we are deliberately keeping the analysis simple and approximate.

The code for `sexp` returns `Unknown` unless the expression uses only `Var`, `Value`, and `Add`. We use the monadic structure of `Sign` to avoid explicitly considering `Unknown` in the `Add` case of `sexp`. There, if either expression has sign `tt` indicating strict positivity, then so does the `Add` expression.

### 5.3 Helper Function for Search

Using the type of signs from the previous section, Figure 15 gives the helper function for type-checking an expression of the form `Search e`, when `e` has the given `Data` type. The first defining equation for `search'` says that it returns `LOOP` if `e` has type `INT` and the sign is strictly positive. If the sign is anything else (second defining equation), the type is `DATA tt INT`, indicating that evaluation of `Search e` will either diverge or produce an integer. If the type for `e` is `BOOL`, then the type is `FAIL ff`, indicating that evaluation of `Search e` will definitely fail, because `e` will evaluate to a boolean. Of course, this is just the helper function for `Search e`. It could happen that the `EType` computed for `e` indicates possible or certain divergence, failure, or unknown behavior. The monad takes care of all those cases, in the code for `texp`, which is shown next.

### 5.4 The Definition of the Type Checker

Using the helper functions presented above, the code for the type checker `texp` is shown in Figure 16. We use the monadic structure of `EType` throughout, to abstract away handling the various modes of typing, namely failure, certain divergence, and possible divergence. The case for `Search` expressions calls `sexp` (Section 5.2) to get the sign of the expression `e`, and then passes this to the helper function `search'`. The monadic approach results in clean, simple code, while still using helper functions as

```

442 data Sign (A : Set) : Set where
443   Known : A → Sign A
444   Unknown : Sign A
445
446 Pos : Sign  $\mathbb{B}$ 
447 Pos = Known tt
448
449 Nonneg : Sign  $\mathbb{B}$ 
450 Nonneg = Known ff
451
452 returns :  $\forall\{A : \text{Set}\} \rightarrow A \rightarrow \text{Sign } A$ 
453 returns = Known
454
455  $\_>>=s\_ : \forall\{A \ B : \text{Set}\} \rightarrow \text{Sign } A \rightarrow (A \rightarrow \text{Sign } B) \rightarrow \text{Sign } B$ 
456 Known x  $\_>>=s$  f = f x
457 Unknown  $\_>>=s$  f = Unknown
458
459 instance
460   SignMonad : Monad Sign
461   SignMonad = record { return = returns ;  $\_>>=\_ = \_>>=s\_$  }
462

```

Fig. 13. A monadic definition of signs

```

464 sval : Val → Sign  $\mathbb{B}$ 
465 sval (I (mk $\mathbb{Z}$  zero triv)) = Nonneg
466 sval (I (mk $\mathbb{Z}$  (suc n) tt)) = Pos
467 sval (I (mk $\mathbb{Z}$  (suc n) ff)) = Unknown
468 sval (B x) = Unknown
469
470 sresult : Result Val → Sign  $\mathbb{B}$ 
471 sresult (Value v) = sval v
472 sresult Fail = Unknown
473 sresult Loop = Unknown
474
475 sexp : Expr → Sign  $\mathbb{B}$ 
476 sexp Var = Nonneg
477 sexp (Value x) = sval x
478 sexp (Add e e') =
479   do
480     s  $\leftarrow$  sexp e
481     s'  $\leftarrow$  sexp e'
482     return (s || s')
483 sexp _ = Unknown
484

```

Fig. 14. Signs of values (Val), results (Result Val), and expressions (Expr)

```

491 search' : Data → Sign  $\mathbb{B}$  → EType Data
492 search' INT (Known tt) = LOOP
493 search' INT _ = DATA tt INT
494 search' _ _ = FAIL ff

```

Fig. 15. Helper function for type-checking Search expressions

```

497
498 texp : Expr → EType Data
499 texp Var = return INT
500 texp (Value v) = return (tval v)
501 texp (Add e1 e2) =
502   do
503     t1 ← texp e1
504     t2 ← texp e2
505     add' t1 t2
506 texp (IsZero e) =
507   do
508     t ← texp e
509     isZero' t
510 texp (Cond e1 e2 e3) =
511   do
512     t1 ← texp e1
513     cond' t1 (texp e2) (texp e3)
514 texp (Search e) =
515   do
516     t ← texp e
517     search' t (sexp e)
518

```

Fig. 16. The type checker texp

advocated by Garby et al. An even bigger payoff of the monadic approach will appear in the next section, where we prove their soundness property, for this richer setting.

## 6 RELATING TYPING AND EVALUATION

In this section, we prove the specification proposed by Garby et al., that the static type of an expression approximates the type of its runtime value. We formulate this soundness property as:

```

527 texp e << tresult (eval g e v)

```

where all the functions mentioned have been defined above, and  $\ll$  is the relation between ETypes and RTypes defined in Figure 17. Let us consider the various clauses of the definition.  $\ll$ Unknown says that the static type UNKNOWN approximates any runtime type T. This clause expresses the same idea that Garby et al. proposed, as shown in the definition of  $\leq$  in Figure 1. It allows the type checker to signal uncertainty, whenever desired, by returning type UNKNOWN. The clause  $\ll$ Data says that if the static type is DATA b T, then the runtime type may be DATA T. The critical point here is that the static type can indicate (via boolean b) that a term might diverge, and it is still acceptable if the runtime type indicates that it actually did converge to a value of type T. A similar idea is expressed in the clause  $\ll$ Fail for the FAIL type. The clause  $\ll$ Unfinished expresses that any static type is acceptable for a computation that has not yet finished. This might seem counterintuitive, because

```

data _<<_ : EType Data → RType → Set where
  <<Unknown : ∀ {T} → UNKNOWN << T
  <<Data : ∀ {T}{b} → DATA b T << DATA T
  <<Fail : ∀ {b} → FAIL b << FAIL
  <<Unfinished : ∀ {T} → T << UNFINISHED

```

Fig. 17. The relation we prove between static and runtime types

```

⌋mono : ∀{e : EType Data}{r : RType}{b : B} →
  e << r →
  (b ⌋ e) << r
⊠lb1 : ∀{a b : EType Data}{a' b' : RType} →
  a << a' →
  b << b' →
  a ⊠ b << a'
⊠lb2 : ∀{a b : EType Data}{a' b' : RType} →
  a << a' →
  b << b' →
  a ⊠ b << b'

```

Fig. 18. Several lemmas about the relation between static and runtime types

some static types indicate convergence. In fact, with our expression language, it cannot happen that a term is statically judged to be terminating, but for some smaller values of the fuel parameter to the interpreter evaluation produces `Unfinished`. But the specification allows that, and it could occur, if the type checker reported solvability of polynomials, not just unsolvability. So with our language, the only case where `<<Unfinished` can arise is when `T` is `LOOP`. This is, of course, a critical case, because it expresses the desired soundness property when the type checker reports `LOOP`: the evaluator must always return `Unfinished` in that situation.

Several lemmas about the relation on types are listed in Figure 18. The first says that relaxing the possibility of divergence in a static type preserves the relation. The next two express the basic order-theoretic property that  $\sqcap$  computes a lower bound. These properties are also used by Garby et al. for their relation. The proofs of these are straightforward.

## 6.1 Monadic Structure of the Relation

The relation `<<` of Figure 17 exhibits a monadic structure, which we use below to abstract common reasoning about errors from the proof of soundness. The combinators corresponding to monadic return and bind are shown in Figure 19. The first, `return<<`, relates the values produced by the return combinators of the `EType` and `Result` monads. The second is more complex. It aims to relate two binds:

- (1) `a >>=e f` in the `EType` monad, and
- (2) `a' >>=r f'` in the `Result` monad.

These can be related if first, `a << tresult a'`. Second, we have a complex condition with a number of hypotheses:

- `v : Val`
- `b : B`
- `a ≡ DATA b (tval v)`

```

589 return<< : ∀{v : Val} →
590         returne (tval v) << tresult (returnr v)
591 return<<{v} = <<Data
592
593 _>>=<<_ : ∀{a : EType Data}{a' : Result Val} →
594         {f : Data → EType Data}{f' : Val → Result Val} →
595         a << tresult a' →
596         (∀{v : Val}{b : B}
597         {q : a ≡ DATA b (tval v)}
598         {q' : a' ≡ Value v}
599         {q'' : DATA b (tval v) << DATA (tval v)} →
600         f (tval v) << tresult (f' v)) →
601         (a >>= f) << tresult (a' >>=r f')
602

```

Fig. 19. Monadic structure of &lt;&lt;

- $a' \equiv \text{Value } v$
- $\text{DATA } b \text{ (tval } v) \ll \text{DATA (tval } v)$

Providing all these, the monadic combinator then requires

- $f \text{ (tval } v) \ll \text{tresult (f' } v)$

The essence of this requirement (by the combinator, of its caller) is to show that  $f$  and  $f'$  together preserve the relation, for all  $v : \text{Val}$ . The extra premises are provided by the combinator to its caller, to make this easier to show. Providing proofs that the terms  $a$  and  $a'$  referenced in the type of the first argument to the combinator are equal to these specific values ( $\text{DATA } b \text{ (tval } v)$  and  $\text{Value } v$ ) are justified by the situation in which this second argument to the combinator will be invoked; and also turn out to be quite helpful in using the combinator. The premise stating that these values are related by  $\ll$  is provided by the combinator just as a convenience in the proof; it follows from the other premises and the requirement that  $a \ll \text{tresult } a'$ . Note that we cannot declare that this monadic structure is an instance of *Monad*, because the interfaces are different: monads are not dependently typed, but these combinators are. So we cannot use *do*-notation with these, but as we will see next, we can still apply them directly with good effect.

## 6.2 The Proof of Soundness: Base Cases

We turn now to the proof of

```

624 texp-soundness : ∀{e : Expr}{g v : N} →
625                 texp e << tresult (eval g e v)

```

Let us start with the base cases:

```

627 texp-soundness {Value x} {g} {v} = return<<
628 texp-soundness {Var} {g} {v} = <<Data

```

They may both be proved using the return of the monadic proof combinator, although we prefer  $\ll\text{Data}$  (which  $\text{return}\ll$  returns) for the second, because in that case, Agda cannot infer the value for implicit argument  $v$ .

## 6.3 The Proof of Soundness: Arithmetic Cases

Next, let us consider the case for *IsZero*. We must prove

```

636 texp (IsZero e) << tresult (eval g (IsZero e) v)

```

```

638 case-isZero : ∀{v : Val} →
639             isZero' (tval v) << tresult (isZero v)
640 case-isZero {I x} = <<Data
641 case-isZero {B x} = <<Fail

```

Fig. 20. Lemma for the IsZero case

Unfolding the definitions of the type checker (texp) and evaluator (eval), this goal becomes  
texp e >>=e isZero' << tresult (eval g e v >>=r isZero)

Delightfully, this matches the conclusion of our monadic proof combinator >>=<<, which is  
(a >>=e f) << tresult (a' >>=r f')

Even better, Agda can deduce that in order to apply that combinator, a must be instantiated to  
texp e, f to isZero', a' to eval g e v, and f' to isZero. From the type of the combinator, this  
means we have two subgoals to prove, where the first is

```

653 texp e << tresult (eval g e v)

```

But this is just what the induction hypothesis (i.e., under Curry-Howard, a recursive call to  
texp-soundness) produces for e. So we need only prove the second premise of the combina-  
tor. The proof in Figure 20 is sufficient; it simply does not make use of the extra premises that  
the combinator provides (about the identity of a, etc.). They are not needed here. (As an aside,  
by making those extra premises implicit, we have Agda do the work of discarding them in using  
case-isZero where a function with more implicit arguments is required.) The two cases of the  
proof, for the two constructors of Val, are easily proved from the defining clauses for <<. Those  
cases are:

- 662 (1) isZero' (tval (I x)) << tresult (isZero (I x))
- 663 (2) isZero' (tval (B x)) << tresult (isZero (B x))

From the definitions of izZero' and isZero, these simplify to

- 666 (1) DATA ff BOOL << DATA BOOL, because the static and runtime types of IsZero expressions  
667 applied to integer values are both (forms of) the boolean type; and
- 668 (2) FAIL ff << FAIL, because IsZero fails if applied to booleans.

Notice that the monadic proof combinator has taken care of all the error cases, and of propagating  
the possibility of divergence. So here, it suffices to reason as if the subexpression e is terminating.

Using the monadic proof combinator and this three-line lemma case-isZero, the case of  
texp-soundness for IsZero is very easy:

```

673 texp-soundness {IsZero e} {g} {v} =
674   texp-soundness{e}{g}{v} >>=<<
675   case-isZero

```

We just use the induction hypothesis (i.e., make a recursive call) for e, and connect this with  
case-iszero using the proof combinator.

The case for Add expressions works just as nicely. We have an easy lemma in Figure 21, where we  
relate data in the case of two integer values, and failures in all others. The clause for texp-soundness  
is again very simple, using the combinator:

```

682 texp-soundness {Add e1 e2} {g} {v} =
683   texp-soundness{e1}{g}{v} >>=<<
684   texp-soundness{e2}{g}{v} >>=<<
685   case-add

```

```

687 case-add : ∀{v1 v2 : Val} →
688           add' (tval v1) (tval v2) << tresult (add v1 v2)
689 case-add {I _} {I _} = <<Data
690 case-add {I _} {B _} = <<Fail
691 case-add {B _} {I _} = <<Fail
692 case-add {B _} {B _} = <<Fail

```

Fig. 21. Lemma relating helper functions for typing and evaluation of Add expressions

```

695
696 case-cond : ∀{v1 : Val}{r2 r3 : Result Val}{t2 t3 : EType Data} →
697           t2 << tresult r2 →
698           t3 << tresult r3 →
699           cond' (tval v1) t2 t3 << tresult (cond v1 r2 r3)
700 case-cond {I x} {r2} {r3} {t2} {t3} d1 d2 = <<Fail
701 case-cond {B tt} {r2} {r3} {t2} {t3} d1 d2 = ⊞lb1 d1 d2
702 case-cond {B ff} {r2} {r3} {t2} {t3} d1 d2 = ⊞lb2 d1 d2

```

Fig. 22. Helper lemma for conditionals

## 6.4 The Proof of Soundness: Conditionals

Because evaluation of conditionals is lazy in the then- and else-parts, both the type checker and the evaluator as we saw them above were structured somewhat differently. The proof follows that structure. The case of `texp-soundness` is:

```

711 texp-soundness {Cond e1 e2 e3} {g} {v} =
712   texp-soundness{e1}{g}{v} >>=<< λ{v1} →
713   case-cond{v1} (texp-soundness{e2}{g}{v}) (texp-soundness{e3}{g}{v})

```

We again use the proof-level bind `>>=<<` with a recursive call to `texp-soundness` for the if-part of the conditional. The helper function then accepts the results of the recursive calls for the then- and else-parts. Agda has trouble inferring some of the implicit arguments, so we handle them explicitly using `{v1}`. Figure 22 shows the definition of the helper lemma `case-cond`. We pattern match on the value `v1` for the if-part, accepting proofs `d1` and `d2` of the soundness property for the then- and else-parts of the conditional. If `v1` is an integer value, then the goal simplifies to

```

720 FAIL ff << FAIL

```

This is proved by `<<Fail`. The other two cases are for when `v1` is `B tt` or `B ff`. In those cases, the goals simplify to

- `t2 ⊞ t3 << tresult r2`
- `t2 ⊞ t3 << tresult r3`

We see here the `⊞` operator, used in the definition of `cond'` (the helper function used by the type checker `texp`, for conditionals). These goals are instances of the ordering properties `⊞lb1` and `⊞lb2`, stated in Figure 18 above. So we prove those cases (in Figure 22) just using those lemmas.

## 6.5 Interlude: Soundness of the Positivity Analysis

Before we see the proof of soundness for Search expressions, we need to consider soundness of the positivity analysis `sexp`. This is formulated again in the style of Garby et al. [3]:

```

733 sexp-soundness : ∀{e : Expr}{g v : ℕ} →
734   sexp e <<sign sresult (eval g e v)

```

```

736 data _<<sign_ : Sign B → Sign B → Set where
737   <<Unknown : ∀ {s} → Unknown <<sign s
738   <<Refl : ∀ {s} → s <<sign s
739   <<Nonneg : Nonneg <<sign Pos

```

Fig. 23. The ordering on signs

```

743 _>=><<sign_ : ∀{a : Sign B}{a' : Result Val} →
744   {f : B → Sign B}{f' : Val → Result Val} →
745   a <<sign sresult a' →
746   (∀{b : B}{v : Val}{q : a ≡ Known b}{q' : a' ≡ Value v} →
747     Known b <<sign sval v →
748     f b <<sign sresult (f' v)) →
749   (a >=>s f) <<sign sresult (a' >=>r f')

```

Fig. 24. Proof-level monadic bind, for proving soundness of sexp

Here, the partial order is as shown in Figure 23, and it follows the same basic idea as the ordering for types (of Figure 17): lower in the ordering corresponds to greater uncertainty. The Unknown type is a minimal element, and Nonneg is less than Pos (as it reflects the additional uncertainty of whether a term might evaluate to zero or else be strictly positive). The proof of sexp-soundness (omitted) is simpler than the proof of soundness for texp, which we are in the middle of presenting. For Add expressions, it uses a similar proof-level monadic bind operator, shown in Figure 24. As for typing, this operator is for relating two monadic results:

```

761 (a >=>s f) <<sign sresult (a' >=>r f')

```

Also as for typing, it requires proofs of the relation, for the components of these monadic results:

- $a \ll \text{sign sresult } a'$
- $\forall \{b : B\} \{v : Val\} \rightarrow \text{Known } b \ll \text{sign sval } v \rightarrow f \ b \ll \text{sign sresult } (f' \ v)$

The second condition states that if the sign of  $v$  is known to be  $b$ , then the relation should hold of  $f \ b$  and  $f' \ v$ . Using this combinator results in a very simple case of sexp-soundness for Add expressions.

## 6.6 The Proof of Soundness: Search

Returning now to the proof of texp-soundness, we have the last case, namely for Search expressions. This is the most involved, because both the type checker and evaluator are most complicated for these expressions. The type checker uses the approximated positivity analysis sexp. The evaluator loops through values for the variable, searching for zero, using mutually recursive helper functions search and searchh. Recall that these functions use an input  $vv : \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \text{Result Val}$ , to avoid having any direct dependence on expressions for the helper function. We have (from Figure 7)

- `search g vv` searches for a value less than or equal to  $g$  where `vv` successfully returns zero.
- `searchh g vv u` checks if  $u$  is zero, returning integer value  $g$ , and continuing the search otherwise, if enough gas remains.

Not surprisingly, the proof needs mutually recursive lemmas to match this structure. These are stated in Figure 25



```

mutual
case-search :  $\forall \{s : \text{Sign } \mathbb{B}\} \{vv : \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \text{Result Val}\} \{g : \mathbb{N}\} \rightarrow$ 
  ( $\forall \{n : \mathbb{N}\} \rightarrow \text{DATA } tt \text{ INT} \ll \text{tresult } (vv \ n) \rightarrow$ 
    ( $\forall \{n : \mathbb{N}\} \rightarrow s \ll \text{sign sresult } (vv \ n) \rightarrow$ 
      search' INT s  $\ll$  tresult (search g vv)
    )
case-searchh :  $\forall \{u : \text{Val}\} \{s : \text{Sign } \mathbb{B}\} \{vv : \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \text{Result Val}\} \{g : \mathbb{N}\} \{b : \mathbb{B}\} \rightarrow$ 
  ( $\forall \{n : \mathbb{N}\} \rightarrow \text{DATA } b \ (tval \ u) \ll \text{tresult } (vv \ n) \rightarrow$ 
    ( $\forall \{n : \mathbb{N}\} \rightarrow s \ll \text{sign sresult } (vv \ n) \rightarrow$ 
      s  $\ll$  sign sval u  $\rightarrow$ 
      search' (tval u) s  $\ll$  tresult (searchh g vv u)
    )

```

Fig. 25. Helper lemmas about searchh and search

These lemmas require some additional hypotheses about  $vv : \mathbb{N} \rightarrow \text{Result Val}$ . First, with  $s$  the sign of the original expression  $e$  (where  $e$  is not presented to these lemmas), both lemmas need the assumption

$$\forall \{n : \mathbb{N}\} \rightarrow s \ll \text{sign sresult } (vv \ n)$$

This says the sign of the calls to  $vv$  is approximated by  $s$ . Where we invoke `case-search` in the proof of `texp-soundness`, we will instantiate  $s$  with `sexp e` and  $vv$  with `eval g e`. So the required property about the sign of  $vv$  becomes

$$\forall \{n : \mathbb{N}\} \rightarrow \text{sexp } e \ll \text{sign sresult } (\text{eval } g \ e \ n)$$

And this is exactly the conclusion of `sexp-soundness`, which we saw in the previous section.

The second requirement of `case-search` is that

$$\forall \{n : \mathbb{N}\} \rightarrow \text{DATA } tt \text{ INT} \ll \text{tresult } (vv \ n)$$

This says that  $vv$  only produces values of data type `INT`. A similar requirement is imposed by `case-searchh`. These properties are proved, in the body of `texp-soundness`, by the induction hypothesis, which applies to any value  $n$  for the sole variable. The proof of `case-search` uses the proof-level `bind`, although Agda needs more help in inferring the implicit arguments. So the code does not look as nice. Still, the combinator abstracts the reasoning about failure cases, and thus keeps the proofs shorter.

To conclude, the complete proof of soundness is listed in Figure 26, omitting only local definitions of  $h$  and  $h'$  in the final case. These do some local rewriting with the results of `texp-soundness` and `sexp-soundness`, which is needed because Agda does not support rewriting inline, but only as part of pattern matching.

## 7 RELATED WORK

This paper is, as extensively noted above, strongly inspired by Garby et al. [3]. For other related works: indexed monads appear in Hoare Type Theory and work on Dijkstra monads [5, 7]. They are used for dependently typed programming in the presence of effects. In contrast, this paper has demonstrated use of an indexed monad for concise relational reasoning about other monadic computations. Delaware et al. [2] do relate monadic computations, in the context of modular proofs of type safety in the presence of effects. They do not structure the proofs themselves monadically, as done here. Swierstra [8] shows how to assemble effectful interpreters using free monads. His work does not concern formalized relational reasoning about these. There is, of course, a voluminous literature on proofs of type safety, too vast to survey here. See Pierce [6] for a starting point.

```

834  texp-soundness : ∀{e : Expr}{g v : ℕ} →
835      texp e << tresult (eval g e v)
836  texp-soundness {Value x} {g} {v} = return<<
837  texp-soundness {Var} {g} {v} = return<<{v = I (toℤ v)}
838  texp-soundness {Add e1 e2} {g} {v} =
839      texp-soundness{e1}{g}{v} >>=<<
840      texp-soundness{e2}{g}{v} >>=<<
841      case-add
842  texp-soundness {IsZero e} {g} {v} =
843      texp-soundness{e}{g}{v} >>=<<
844      case-isZero
845  texp-soundness {Cond e1 e2 e3} {g} {v} =
846      texp-soundness{e1}{g}{v} >>=<< λ{v1} →
847      case-cond{v1}
848      (texp-soundness{e2}{g}{v})
849      (texp-soundness{e3}{g}{v})
850  texp-soundness {Search e} {g} {v} =
851      texp-soundness{e}{g}{g} >>=<<
852      λ{u}{b}{q}{q'} →
853      case-searchhh{u}{b = b}
854      (λ{n} → h {u} q)
855      (sexp-soundness{e})
856      (h' q')

```

Fig. 26. Proof of soundness of the type checker with respect to the evaluator

## 8 CONCLUSION AND FUTURE WORK

We have seen how to extend the inspiring approach of Garby et al. [3] to distinguish between errors and uncertainty. The kinds of errors we consider are divergence and finite failure. We extend their example expression language with a form of unbounded search, for which we use a simple sound – but intentionally incomplete – divergence analysis. The approach depends on a more complex partial ordering of types, where total uncertainty (type UNKNOWN) is minimal, and progression in the ordering corresponds to increasing certainty. We used monads to manage the several different kinds of errors, both in typing and evaluation. To prove Garby et al.’s relational specification – that the static type approximates the runtime type of the result of the interpreter – we use a proof-level binary indexed monad. This factors out all the reasoning about errors, and results in a concise and manageable proof of soundness, both for typing and the positivity analysis (for divergence). Using the standard technique of a fuel-based interpreter, we are able to perform this relational reasoning about possibly diverging evaluation.

Probably the most pressing avenue for future work is to extend the approach of Garby et al. to higher-order functions. Here, it seems likely that the idea of relating static types of expressions with runtime types of results of evaluation will break down. This is because in the presence of higher-order functions, computing the runtime type for a functional value will no longer be simple or even, for many type systems of interest, decidable. Even if results are restricted to be first-order, the soundness property will have to be extended to higher order, to reason about intermediate steps of computation. For this, instead of relating static and runtime types, one might be better off relating static types and results of evaluation directly. This might take the approach closer

to usual semantic approaches in Programming Languages, like step-indexed logical relations [1]. Finally, we have only proven a soundness property relating typing to evaluation. Also of interest would be a liveness property: if the static type indicates termination, then indeed, there is a value for the fuel parameter for which the evaluator will terminate with either Fail or a value. This should be relatively simple to prove here, because our static typing does not report any terms terminating that contain Search. In general, however, the problem of proving termination for a total language can be challenging, and is beyond the scope of our extension of Garby et al. [3].

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